

Fatal error: Not enough memory

There's a standing joke in the office, where the team teases me about my skewed memory. Almost every time someone suggests an article idea, my standard response is, "But haven't we already done that article?". I then go on to explain in detail the article we wrote, only to be met by blank faces. Someone then quickly searches through our PDF archives and jovially retorts, "Yeah. We did that story in 2004. A lot of new stuff has happened since then." Peals of laughter follow.

Over eight years of writing and editing articles for the same magazine does that to you. Someone once called it "time compression", where I vividly remember articles, but forget how long ago they were written. Of course, I also remember every conversation about articles that I've had on the phone with a team member, but I don't know a single person's phone number, despite calling them 987235 times a day!

It's a form of selective memory that all of us are being forced into – our brains just delete old information the way you clean up your drive to free up some space for new information. I'd love to believe that our brains are sending only useless information to the recycle bin, but I seriously doubt it.

As I've said before in this space, (September 2009 – I looked up the PDFs because I couldn't remember when) teachers feel that long term memory is reducing with each generation. A lot of kids today easily forget what they learnt just a few days ago, unless the teachers find a way to make it a familiar form of learning, and put it up as a video, or make a clickable and fun interface. There's just too much information, and most of it useless.

Adults also rely too much on technology to do just about anything. We use reminder software to tell us what to do today, and rely on Facebook to tell us whose birthday it is. A lot of us don't remember what we studied in college, and some of us even forget our own passwords!

In terms of tech, most people have software knowledge, but very few hardware skills. I've interviewed geeks who have been coding for 4 years, but never

assembled a PC themselves. If we get a virus, or screw up some system setting, we Google the solution and fix the problem. If the same problem recurs a week later, we probably will not remember the solution and just Google for it again.

A tiny new section called Space Age that we've started this month is what prompted this column. The topic of the month is solar flares, and looks at whether there really is any threat to the Earth from our own sun. Some scientists suggest that electromotive forces or electromagnetic pulses could wipe out all technology on Earth. Such an event, if it were to happen, may not result in the annihilation of the human race, but it would certainly cause billions to take a few steps back on the evolutionary chain.

If Hollywood flicks that deal with the topic are anything to go by, then we're all going to descend into caveman-like animals, where only the physically fittest survive. What would we do without electricity, the internet or our cell phones? If you had to fix a blown transformer today, could you? If we had to live off the land, would we know anything about farming? Very few of us have actual libraries at home that we can consult, because most reading these days is done on screens... However, ask yourself this: how much do you really know without any technology to assist you?

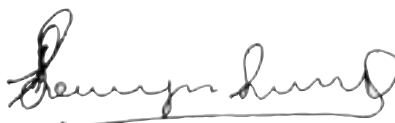
Now I'm not suggesting that you drop everything you're doing and start reading survival guides, build bomb shelters and arm yourself to the teeth. That's crazy talk. It can't hurt, though, to limit our brain's dependence on technology by trying to remember more and click less. It wouldn't be too bad to encourage our children to learn their basics, and to do it through understanding and not rote learning.

I don't think anyone wants to see us head down the path where humanity experiences the ultimate BSOD that says, "Fatal Error: Not enough memory to survive." 



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